religious demands of the Sikhs. As it turned out these were mere words, with no matching follow-up action. Then, in June 1983, she announced the constitution of a ‘one-man commission’ headed by a retired Supreme Court judge, Justice R.S. Sarkaria, to look into the structure of Centre-state relations as enshrined in the Constitution and suggest changes, if any, that were required to meet the growing aspirations of the states.

Had the prime minister made these concessions to the Akali Dal delegation during the latest round of negotiations that failed just a few months before in February, the Akalis could have projected them as their own achievement, giving them some reasonable grounds to withdraw their morcha. In the context of the failed February talks, Surjeet said it was the third time in six months that Indira Gandhi had backed out of agreements. It was during this time that Mark Tully met Bhindranwale in his room at Guru Nanak Niwas. When Tully asked him a direct question, ‘Do you or do you not support the demand of Khalistan, Sikh independent state?’, Bhindranwale replied, ‘I am neither in favour of it nor against it. If the government gives us, we won’t reject it.’ [27]

Following this, a number of rounds of talks and negotiations continued to take place between the Akali Dal and Central government functionaries/nominees in the period leading up to Operation Blue Star. All met with the same fate as the earlier ones. However, in this intervening period one internal discussion held by Akali Dal in Amrtisar, and the last round of talks between the Akalis and the Central government in New Delhi merits special mention.

Following the failure of the talks in February 1984, Longowal called a meeting of Akali Dal leaders at Amritsar, to discuss the future course of their Dharam Yudh Morcha. It was generally felt that as the morcha had been hijacked by Bhindranwale, which was doing more harm than good to the Sikhs, it would be better to suspend or even withdraw it unconditionally. While a consensus was emerging in favour of that decision, Balwant Singh, former finance minister in the Badal government, stood up and made a provocative speech, saying that after having made so many sacrifices, suspension or withdrawal of the morcha would be a betrayal of the Sikh cause.